

AROUND THE TOWN

with

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The large-lettered sign across the front of the small neat, brick house on Louisa street, just west of Booth, caught the eye. In English and Italian, it read:

M. IERULLO

REAL ESTATE BROKER

Ottawa's First Real Estate Office to Help
Canadians and New Canadians

of Average Earnings

"M" is for Mary and the slightly plump and decidedly attractive young matron behind the desk in the business-like office, the front room of her home, was the first Italian real estate broker to set up in this town. This was in October, 1957, and today she employs 10 full-time agents who, between them, can buy and sell houses in English, Italian, French, Spanish, Portuguese, Mexican and Hebrew.

Signora Ierullo (pronounced Eye-rule-o) went to work by necessity. Her husband, Vincent, a bakery worker, suffered three successive accidents on the job. He can only do the light work and that's hard to get. Workmen's Compensation pays him \$16 a month and nobody has yet discovered how to keep a wife and three small children on an income of that size.

In 1955, following her husband's second accident, Italian-born Mary Ierullo, a civil servant prior to her marriage, saw a newspaper advertisement for real estate agents. She got a job with the firm and two months later was asked to open an office for it on Booth street. There, she soon had seven agents working under her.

Two years later she passed the examinations for real estate broker, scoring 97 percent, and opened her own office. Next May, she's moving to larger premises at Rochester and Willow streets.

"I hope", this dark-eyed, dark-haired woman with the gleaming smile said, "by the time my children have grown up there will be a real business for them."

Right today their mother is one of the best known residents and a leading figure in the Italian Village. Her efforts on behalf of the flood of immigrants from her native Italy and elsewhere in Europe have gained her quite a reputation. And they've helped her business.

"The greatest handicap immigrants suffer under", she said, "is being unable to speak the language of their new country. They suffer in attempts to handle the simplest things, make the most ordinary arrangements. They are so unsure of themselves it is pitiable and they must have help."

This is the reason why Mary Ierullo acted as a volunteer interpreter for six years at Ottawa Civic's pre-natal clinic. The curtains of her office, a painting on its wall and the tall ashstand were gifts from some of the women she was able to help.

It is the reason why for the past few winters she's spent so much time trying to help the unemployed of St. Anthony's parish find jobs. Seventy-five percent of its new parishioners are seasonal laborers who can't speak English. If it weren't, she says, for the great, untiring efforts of Father Jerome, there, their plight last Winter would have been far more serious.

It is the reason, too, why her real estate office is a kind of free service bureau. Half a dozen calls a day from people with problems are about average. One came in while we were with her.

After three minutes of rapid fire Italian she called the building inspection office at City Hall and explained

that this particular party had been unable to find the size of window approved for the one-bedroom addition to his house. Could he use another size that was available? He could, pleasant comments were exchanged on the telephone, and she relayed the information to her information seeker.

"These people", she said, "are trying so hard to make good here one has to help them. Life isn't easy for them but they are happy in this land. They feel that here their children will have a better chance than they had and they're willing to work hard, and long hours of overtime, so they will be sure of getting it."

One of these is Donato, a 21-year-old tile-layer in Canada a year and a half. Donato hasn't any children yet but he is sending to Italy for his fiancée next year and soon, no doubt, there will be lots of bambini. Already he is a man of property.

"All our real estate signs are in red, white and green, the Italian tri-color", said Signora Ierullo. "They're bright and catch the eye just like yours was caught."

"So, we put this sign up a few days ago outside one of a semi-detached row on Preston street. Two hours later Donato walked in. We took him to look at it and he wrote his cheque for \$2,000 for the down payment right away. The owner had bought a new home so we had to get Donato, who lives with his cousin, a tenant. We did that and Donato can easily make his payments out of his rents."

The word gets around Italian Village and other such sections of cities when there are persons ready to help strangers in a strange land. It has got around about Mary Ierullo and it bustles success is built on friendship and kindness hers is on its way to prosper in a big way.